

CHARIOT

BRAND STRATEGY

Internal working document — not for external distribution

SECTION 1: WHO WE ARE

The Problem We Exist to Solve

There is a specific moment that happens constantly inside diaspora communities, creative circles, and anywhere people with genuinely good taste congregate. Someone walks in wearing something that stops the room. Not because it's loud. Because it's right in a way that nothing in any store near you is right. You ask where they got it. The answer is always somewhere you can't easily get to — Japan, Lagos, Accra, a market in Marrakech, a designer you've never heard of who doesn't ship internationally, or a brand that technically ships but will take three weeks, hit you with a customs bill you didn't budget for, and maybe never arrive at all.

That moment — the wanting without the access — is the entire business.

The problem is not that people don't know great fashion exists outside America. The problem is that getting it here is an obstacle course: find the brand, DM them, hope they ship internationally, wait, get hit by customs, pay fees you didn't expect, and if something's wrong, you have no recourse because the return policy doesn't apply across borders. Every one of those steps is a place where desire dies.

This isn't a shipping problem. It's a trust problem. People don't trust that the thing they want will actually arrive, cost what they expect, and be returnable if it's wrong. So they don't try.

What Chariot Is

Chariot is the answer to "where did you get that?" — specifically for independent fashion from West Africa and beyond — that doesn't end in a customs nightmare or a tracking number that goes cold.

We go directly to the brands. We buy wholesale. We handle every customs detail ourselves. We bring the inventory to the US. When you order, you're ordering from New York, not Accra. The piece ships in days. Returns are free. The price you see is the price you pay.

The drop is chosen by the community. You vote on what we bring. We bring exactly what you asked for — no speculation, no guessing, no inventory we bought on a hunch. Real demand. Real order.

We started in Accra because that's where we have relationships. Nigeria is next. Then anywhere there's a brand worth knowing that hasn't made it here yet.

What We Are Not

We are not a marketplace. We don't aggregate every brand from everywhere and let you sort by price. We curate. We have a point of view. We bring specific things from specific places because we have relationships there and because we believe those things are worth bringing.

We are not a dropshipper. We don't forward your order to a warehouse in Accra and hope for the best. We are the importer of record. We own the inventory in the US before you order it. That is the entire structural difference between the experience we provide and the experience of buying direct.

We are not a charity or a cultural project. We are a fashion company. We happen to source from places the American market has ignored, but we are not doing this out of obligation or altruism. We are doing this because the fashion is genuinely better, the moment is right, and no one else has built the infrastructure to make it work.

The Positioning Statement

Chariot is where independent global fashion becomes purchasable in America — on American terms, with American trust standards, at the speed Americans expect.

The slogan: What the rest of the world is already wearing.

This line does three things simultaneously. It signals that the fashion already exists and already has an audience elsewhere — you're not discovering it, you're catching up. It creates mild FOMO without hysteria. And it positions Chariot as the access mechanism, not the origin. We didn't make this. We made it possible to have it.

The Values

Not for the website — for every decision we make.

- Specificity over generality. We name the brand, the city, the designer, the fabric. We never say "African fashion." We say 1Nri, Accra, structured collar, wax-resist fabric. The specificity is the credibility.
- Curation over volume. We bring thirty pieces that we believe in rather than three hundred pieces that are available. The quality of the selection is the product. This is what separates us from a marketplace.
- Operational transparency. We show the math. We tell people what the tariff costs, what the shipping costs, what the margin is. We don't hide the markup — we justify it line by line. Trust is built through transparency, not polish.
- Community before inventory. We do not buy what we think people want. We ask them, we let them commit financially, and we buy what they proved they want. This is not a marketing mechanic. It is the structural foundation of how we operate.
- Cultural authority through humility. We did not invent this fashion. The designers in Accra built it. Our job is to bring it here without diluting it, without exoticizing it, and without taking credit for it. Chariot's authority is borrowed from the brands until we earn our own.

SECTION 2: WHO WE'RE FOR

The Abstract — The Psychology of the Person Who Asks "Where Did You Get That"

The moment itself has an anatomy. Someone walks into a room wearing something and a specific type of person stops them. Not everyone stops them — most people don't notice, or notice and move on. The person who asks is a specific psychological type, and understanding exactly what is happening inside them when they ask is the foundation of everything Chariot does.

Before any conscious thought, the visual system has already registered an anomaly — this silhouette is wrong in a way I can't immediately explain, this fabric is doing something I haven't seen before, this piece was clearly made by someone who made decisions rather than optimized for cost. The anomaly triggers approach. The question comes out. None of this was deliberate. Interest happened to the person before they chose to be interested.

Underneath that automatic firing is a status read. Humans are running a continuous, subconscious status detection system at all times, reading every person in their environment for signals of rank, knowledge, and group membership. The unusual piece fires that system with a specific signal: this person has access to something I don't. They know something I don't.

That status read activates mimetic desire. The person wearing the piece has become a model — not a celebrity or an authority figure operating at a safe distance, but someone in the same social world, close enough to touch, who has something the observer wants. Mimetic desire fires precisely because the gap is small enough to imagine closing.

So when the question gets asked, what the asker is really asking is not "where is the store." They are asking: can I enter the world you belong to? The piece is a door. The question is whether the door opens.

Chariot's entire existence is the conversion of that frustrated desire into a fulfillable one. Things acquired with effort are valued more than things acquired without it. The community pre-order, the voting mechanism, the founding member structure, the limited drop window — these exist because desire that costs nothing to fulfill becomes worth nothing once fulfilled.

The Particular — The Niche Hunter

The pivot from the diaspora-first framing to this one is not a retreat. It is a more honest read of how desire actually moves in the niche streetwear world. The right frame is not "Ghanaian fashion for the diaspora." The right frame is "niche streetwear that happens to come from Accra, for the person who hunts niche."

Who They Are

The Niche Hunter is 19–26. They live in a city or go to school in one. They have a considered relationship to what they wear — not necessarily expensive, but deliberate. They have already moved through at least one mainstream fashion cycle and come out the other side with contempt for it. Fast fashion is not just aesthetically wrong to them — it is a moral failure.

They are already hunting. They follow accounts that are three steps ahead of what's in stores. They know brands that their peers haven't heard of and they feel the specific pleasure of being asked about something they're wearing before the person asking has any context for it.

Their Enneagram profile is the 4 with a 3 wing, occasionally shading into the 7. The core fear is being ordinary. The core desire is to be recognized as specifically themselves — to have a taste that is legible as individual rather than copied.

What Activates Them

- They need to see the piece on someone they actually respect before they'll move. Not an influencer. Not a brand account. Someone in their actual social orbit who they read as having better taste than them.
- They need the story to be real and specific. "This brand has been in Accra's creative scene for three years and this is their first US drop" is exactly the kind of sentence that works on them.
- They need the acquisition to have the right amount of friction. Too easy and the thing loses its value immediately. The community pre-order model is correct for this customer.
- They need the piece itself to pass the MAYA test against their existing reference points. A structured collar they've never seen, a woven piece with a pattern that has no American equivalent, a silhouette that uses the body differently — these work.

Where They Congregate

Digitally: Instagram accounts for independent labels, archive fashion accounts, brands that are three steps ahead of mainstream, the specific corners of TikTok where people break down construction and materials.

Physically: art school adjacent events, independent brand pop-ups, vintage and archive markets, the creative communities at universities with strong art and design programs — New York, LA, Atlanta, Chicago, DC.

What They Are Not

- They are not buying Chariot because it's Ghanaian. They are buying Chariot because it's genuinely good, genuinely rare, and genuinely from somewhere with a real story.
- They are not the hotep customer. The hotep customer is motivated by cultural politics. The Niche Hunter is motivated by taste. These are not the same person and targeting both simultaneously will confuse the brand into incoherence.
- They are not a loyal customer yet. Loyalty comes from the drop being real, the piece being what it was described as, and the experience of ordering from Chariot being materially better than the alternatives.

SECTION 3: PRODUCT PHILOSOPHY AND SELECTION CRITERIA

The Philosophy

Chariot is not in the business of selling Ghanaian fashion. Chariot is in the business of finding the pieces that the rest of the world is already wearing before the American market knows they exist — and making those pieces available without the obstacle course. The geographic origin is a quality signal and a story, not a category.

When evaluating a piece from 1Nri or Jireh or any brand after them, the first question is never "does this represent Ghanaian fashion well?" The first question is "would a Niche Hunter stop someone wearing this and ask where they got it?"

The Three Pillars

Pillar 1 — The Piece Must Be Able to Stand Alone

Before the story is attached, before the Accra origin is mentioned, before the designer's name is invoked — the piece must do something visually. A stranger with no context must be capable of being stopped by it. This is the visceral test and it is non-negotiable. If the piece only works with the story, the story is doing work that the piece should be doing.

This means: no basics for Drop 1. Not because basics are bad, but because basics cannot pass the visceral test against the Niche Hunter's elevated baseline.

Pillar 2 — The Strangeness Must Be Traceable to Origin

The Niche Hunter needs the piece to be doing something that is only possible because of where it comes from. Not "inspired by African aesthetics" in the way American fast fashion brands do it — an abstraction of a cultural signal stripped of its actual logic. The specific fabric tradition of West African textile production, the specific construction approaches that emerge from a specific design community in Accra.

The familiar half of the MAYA equation should come from the piece's relationship to the customer's existing reference points. The strange half should come unmistakably from Accra.

Pillar 3 — Construction Must Meet the Story

The Niche Hunter will physically examine what they buy. They will look at the seams. They will assess the fabric weight. They will notice whether the finishing was done with care. A piece with a great story and poor construction is worse than a piece with no story and poor construction, because the story raised their expectations and the construction betrayed them.

This means Chariot needs to physically handle the pieces before they go into a drop. Not from photos. From the actual garment.

The Four Selection Gates

When evaluating any piece for a Chariot drop, run it through four gates in sequence. A piece that fails any gate doesn't make the drop.

Gate 1 — The Stranger Test

Imagine the piece on a person walking through a room full of people whose fashion baseline is elevated. Does the piece stop someone? Not because it's loud. Because it's doing something they haven't seen before in a way they can immediately understand. If the honest answer is no, it fails Gate 1 regardless of what else is true about it.

Gate 2 — The Origin Test

Can you look at the piece and trace the strangeness back to where it comes from? Is the thing that makes it unusual something that is only possible because of the specific design tradition, fabric tradition, or construction approach that comes from Accra? The strangeness should be rooted, not floating.

Gate 3 — The Construction Test

Handle the piece. Not from photos. From the actual garment. Does the fabric weight communicate quality, does the finishing reflect care, are the seams executed with intention, does the piece hold its structure when worn? No exceptions.

Gate 4 — The Drop Coherence Test

Does the piece fit with the other pieces in the same drop? A drop is a curatorial statement. Each piece in it should feel like it comes from the same world, should make the other pieces feel more inevitable rather than less, and should together tell a story that is legible in a single look.

SECTION 4: BRAND VOICE

The Position We Own

Chariot is the only brand that brings fashion from cities the American market hasn't caught up to yet, for people who hunt niche before the market arrives.

Every word Chariot says, every image Chariot posts, every decision about color and type and layout is either reinforcing that sentence or diluting it. There is no neutral.

The Gut Feeling

These people already know. They were there before I was. If I follow them, I will be ahead of everyone else I know.

Not: this is a cool new brand I discovered. Not: this is a company trying to get my attention. Not: this is a cultural project I should support. The moment Chariot's communication sounds like it is trying to seem rare, the brand has lost.

The Voice

Chariot speaks like someone who has already been to the places the Niche Hunter is trying to get to, and is telling them what they found. Not with excitement. With the calm specificity of someone who doesn't need validation for what they know.

The register is: guide, not discoverer. Authority, not enthusiasm. Insider sharing access, not outsider announcing arrival.

The image: the person at the dinner table who, when the conversation turns to a place they know well, doesn't say "oh my god you have to go there it's incredible." They say "there's a place on the east side of the medina, second alley past the spice market, the guy has been making the same jacket for thirty years."

In Practice

- Name the specific thing. Never the category. Not "West African fashion." 1Nri. Not "a brand from Accra." The brand that has been dressing Accra's creative class since 2021.
- State facts. Do not praise. "Beautiful" means nothing. "The fabric weight is 280gsm and the topstitching is doubled at every stress point" means something.
- Confidence without pitch energy. Chariot never announces. Never says "we're excited to introduce." Never uses exclamation marks.
- Operational transparency as trust. The price breakdown, the customs math, the timeline from window close to doorstep — stated plainly and completely.
- The customer is the hero. Chariot is the guide. Chariot never makes itself the subject of its own communication.

What the Voice Is Not

- Not tourist. Chariot never describes Accra as exotic, emerging, undiscovered, or any word that positions the American observer as the reference point.

- Not missionary. Chariot is not doing this for the good of African fashion or the cultural education of American consumers.
- Not hype. Drop announcements are factual. Unit counts are stated. Deadlines are stated.
- Not academic. No customer-facing communication references theoretical frameworks.

Before and After

Before: *"We're excited to bring the incredible designs of independent African fashion to US consumers."*

After: **"1Nri has been in Accra's creative scene since 2021. This is their first US drop. 30 units. 14 days."**

Before: *"Chariot is bridging the gap between African designers and American consumers."*

After: **"The piece ships from New York. Duties are paid. The price you see is the price you pay."**

Before: *"Discover the stunning world of West African fashion through our community-driven platform."*

After: **"You voted. We ordered. Drop 1 opens Thursday."**

Visual Identity

Typography

Display: Grand Central or a roman serif in the Cinzel tradition — inscriptional, monumental, rooted in the visual language of things made to last. Not a startup font. Not a tech company font. Operational: a clean geometric or humanist sans for price, shipping information, unit counts, timelines.

Color

Black is the color of fashion authority. Chariot's primary color is black, deep and warm, not pure. Warm neutrals — cream, sand, Harmattan — are the field on which black operates. The single accent — gold, Kente — earns its power through rarity. One instance per layout. No blues. No Pan-African palette.

Photography

No explanation in the image. The garment is in a space. The person wearing it is in their own world, not presenting to the camera. Natural light. Four shots per product: flat lay (the reference fact), on body (fit and scale), macro detail (construction), in context (identity function).

The Onliness Statement

Chariot is the only brand that makes fashion from cities the American market hasn't caught up to yet available in America, for people who already know what the rest of the world is wearing.

SECTION 5: STRATEGY

The Diagnosis

Chariot has two foundational problems right now. The first is trust — nobody knows us and nobody trusts us yet, and trust cannot be manufactured, only earned through consistent delivery over time. The second is marketing — we now have a voice and a position, but we haven't deployed either against a real customer with real money yet.

The secondary challenge is structural. The original plan assumes campus infrastructure — GSA chapters, ambassadors, physical presence, the social density of a college environment. That infrastructure goes dormant in May. The summer is not a slower version of the semester plan. It is a fundamentally different operating environment.

The tertiary challenge is the middleman problem. Chariot has no durable leverage on either side right now. The brands can go direct to the US when they have enough traction here. The customers have no switching cost. The only thing that makes Chariot irreplaceable long-term is the community and the curation — the trust that the community has built with Chariot's editorial judgment, which neither the brands nor the customers can replicate without Chariot in the middle.

The Guiding Policy

Earn the right to the next step before taking it.

Drop 1 is an MVP. Its purpose is not revenue. Its purpose is validated learning — proof that a specific type of person will put real money down on a specific type of piece from a specific type of brand, through this specific model. Every decision about Drop 1 is in service of that learning. Scale comes after the model is validated. Not before.

The Category Chariot Is Creating

The existing category Chariot could be placed in: international fashion retailer. That category has established kings — SSENSE, Farfetch, Net-a-Porter, Wolf & Badger. Chariot cannot compete there without catalog depth, brand recognition, and editorial authority it doesn't have yet.

The new category Chariot creates and owns: community-validated import drops. The customer is not buying from a retailer. They are participating in a collective act of cultural curation that results in a piece of clothing arriving at their door.

The category name: **the drop you voted for.**

The positioning: **you don't buy from Chariot. You build Chariot's drops with your vote and then receive what you built.**

The Beachhead

Chariot's beachhead is not "the African diaspora." That is a demographic, not a psychographic beachhead. The beachhead is Niche Hunters at universities with strong creative communities, concentrated initially around Worcester and the five cities where the team has actual presence and actual relationships — not hypothetical coverage.

Win Worcester completely in the fall. Get twenty people who put real money down, receive a piece they love, and tell people about it. That is the validated learning that makes everything else possible. Not fifty form responses. Twenty real deposits from people who actually receive the product and would buy again.

The Community Validation Sequence

The community is built before Drop 1 through the form and through the founder channel. Everyone who fills out the form is a founding community member — not just a lead, but a participant. The voting mechanism and the curation process are what they are participating in.

- One: Community seeding. Before piece selection, before the form goes live, the founder channel goes active and the first twenty relationships are being built manually.
- Two: Community signal collection. The form goes live with open-ended questions about what types of pieces the community wants, what price points are realistic, what brands they already know.
- Three: Piece selection against the four gates, informed by the community signal.
- Four: Community confirmation. Before the LOI is signed, the shortlisted pieces go back to the founding community for confirmation.
- Five: LOI signed with one brand. One agreement, one brand, one drop.
- Six: Drop 1 opens. 14-day window. Visible unit counter. 50% deposit. Founder channel announces it first. Founding community gets 24 hours before it goes public.
- Seven: Drop 1 closes. Wholesale order placed. Import handled. Pieces shipped from US inventory.
- Eight: Debrief. Full data analysis before Drop 2 is planned.

What Chariot Does Not Do

- No paid advertising before Drop 1 is complete. The Niche Hunter doesn't convert from ads. They convert from social proof from people they respect.
- No second brand for Drop 1. One LOI, one brand, one drop. Curatorial depth over catalog breadth.
- No press outreach before Drop 1. The press story requires a proof point.
- No active investor pitching. The deck gets built after Drop 1 data exists. Before that it's speculation. After that it's evidence.
- No website rush. A polished website for an unvalidated idea is putting a frame on an empty canvas.

SECTION 6: SUMMER EXECUTION PLAN

The Constraint

No campuses. No GSA chapters. Jaden and Shaq are not at Worcester. The team is spread across Worcester, Auburn, Austin, and wherever Red is. The summer is the test of whether Chariot can build without institutional scaffolding.

The Goal by End of August

- Drop 1 closed, validated, and debriefed.
- Founding community of at minimum 50 real people — people who have had a real conversation with someone on the team, filled out the form, and received a personal response.
- Founder channel at minimum 500 followers who are genuinely in the target demographic.
- One signed LOI.
- Drop 1 data in hand.

May — Foundation Month

The single job in May is building the infrastructure before anything is marketed. Nothing public until the infrastructure exists.

- The founder channel goes active. One piece of content per week minimum documenting the build process in the established voice. Not inspirational. Specific.
- The Discord is set up and the founding ten people are invited personally — not blasted, personally.
- The community signal form goes live. What are you looking for that you can't find? What would make you commit 50% deposit to a pre-order? Goal: 30 responses by end of May.
- Each founder commits to one in-person event per week in their city. Non-negotiable.

June — Selection and Validation Month

- Community signal data is analyzed. What did people say they want? What price points came up?
- The team physically handles pieces from 1Nri and Jireh — not from photos. Actual samples. Every piece goes through the four gates. The shortlist is three to five pieces maximum.
- The shortlist goes back to the founding Discord community for confirmation. The community votes. The result is the drop.
- The LOI negotiation begins with the selected brand. Target: LOI signed by end of June.
- Founder channel documents the selection process without revealing specific pieces. Builds credibility for the curation claim before the drop opens.

July — Pre-Drop Month

- The LOI is signed. The wholesale order quantity is confirmed. The drop infrastructure is set up — payment processing, inventory tracking, fulfillment plan.
- The founding community grows by referral, not by broadcast. Each founding member brings in one person they think belongs. Target: 50 real members by end of July.
- The packaging is designed and ordered. Stamp card, hangtag, tissue paper. Ordered this month — it needs to arrive before the drop closes.
- Drop announcement assets are prepared. Four shots per piece: flat lay, on body, macro detail, in context.
- Founder channel builds toward the drop without announcing it. By the time the drop opens, everyone following already knows what is coming and why it matters.

August — Drop Month

Week 1

Drop 1 opens. Founding community gets 24 hours first. Then the founder channel. Then any public announcement. 14-day window. Visible unit counter. 50% deposit. Factual communication only.

Week 2

Mid-drop check. How many units have moved? Which channel drove the most deposits? If conversion is slower than expected, the team does more in-person activation — not more digital content. The Niche Hunter converts from people, not from posts.

Week 3

Drop closes. Wholesale order placed immediately. Import timeline confirmed. Every depositor receives a confirmation with a specific delivery date, not a range.

Week 4

Debrief. Full analysis before anything else is planned. What converted. What didn't. What the customers said. What the pieces looked like when they arrived. Whether the construction held up to the promise. This data is the foundation of Drop 2.

What Success Looks Like at End of August

Drop 1 closed with at minimum 15 real deposits from people who were not personal friends of the founders before the process started. One brand relationship formalized with an LOI and a completed wholesale transaction. A founding community of 50 real people who have had genuine conversations with the team. A founder channel with 500 or more followers in the target demographic. And a debrief document that tells the team exactly what to do differently in Drop 2.

That is the summer. It is not glamorous. It is manual, specific, and measurable. Which means when August ends, we know whether the model works. And if it does, the fall semester — with campus infrastructure back, GSA chapters active, and a proof point in hand — is a completely different game.